



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: WELLINGTON HARBOUR / CABLE CAR

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Wellington Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · TE WHANGANUI-A-TARA



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Wellington — Te Whanganui-a-Tara, New Zealand's capital city.

Wrapped around a dramatic harbour and built between hills and sea, Wellington is famously compact, walkable and creative — a city of cafés, culture and government, often called the coolest little capital in the world.

This guide covers housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: WELLINGTON WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

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QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Southern tip, North Island

CLIMATE

Temperate, breezy

DRIVE/FERRY

Ferry to South Island

MAIN CITY

Wellington (~215,000 city)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Wellington Regional Hospital

NEARBY

Kāpiti Coast, Wairarapa

The coolest little capital

New Zealand's capital sits at the foot of the North Island, a compact harbour city that packs government, arts, film and a celebrated food scene into walkable streets between the hills and the sea.

215K

CITY RESIDENTS

1

OF THE WORLD'S MOST WALKABLE
CAPITALS

Te Papa

NZ'S NATIONAL MUSEUM, ON THE
WATERFRONT

Why many professionals enjoy Wellington

- Compact and genuinely walkable
- A world-class café, craft-beer and dining scene
- The cultural and political heart of the country
- Te Papa, theatre, film and live music on tap

Capital of culture

As the seat of government and home to the national museum Te Papa, Wellington carries an outsized cultural life – film, theatre, festivals and a café culture that locals take seriously.

The city is the centre of New Zealand's film industry, with Weta Workshop and Wellington's studios behind some of cinema's best-known work.

Te Whanganui-a-Tara has a deep Māori history, and a creative, progressive identity reflected in its festivals, galleries and laneway bars.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: WELLINGTON LANDMARK

“

You can walk from Parliament to the waterfront to a hillside café in twenty minutes – that compactness is Wellington's magic.

ON LIFE IN WELLINGTON

Getting around

Here is how people get around Wellington day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

WALKING

The compact CBD means many residents walk to work – one of the city's great advantages.

TRAINS & BUSES

The Metlink network of trains and buses connects the city and the Hutt Valley and Kāpiti.

FERRIES

Harbour ferries and the Cook Strait ferry to the South Island depart from the city.

AIR

Wellington Airport links the capital to domestic and trans-Tasman destinations.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Wellington has a temperate maritime climate — mild temperatures year-round, but known for its wind. Clear, calm days reward the city with spectacular harbour views.

Summer

DEC – FEB

18–22°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

14–19°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

8–12°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

13–17°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: MOUNT VICTORIA LOOKOUT / CUBA STREET

Wellington's wind is real — locals dress in layers and carry a sturdy jacket. But on a calm, clear day, few cities in the world look better.

Healthcare in Wellington

Health New Zealand I Te Whatu Ora delivers care across the capital region, anchored by Wellington Regional Hospital — a major tertiary centre for the lower North Island and upper South Island.

Wellington Regional Hospital (Newtown)

A major tertiary teaching hospital with acute, surgical and specialist services, serving the lower North Island and beyond.

Hutt Hospital (Lower Hutt)

Serves the Hutt Valley with acute, medical, surgical and maternity services.

Kenepuru (Porirua)

Provides community, elective and outpatient services north of the city.

Private & ACC

Wellington has private hospital options such as Wakefield and Bowen; ACC covers accidents for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Wellington

As the capital, Wellington's costs sit below Auckland but above the regions, with compact city living often trading space for walkability and convenience.

\$650/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.80/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Wellington renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,500 – \$2,400
Power & water	\$150 – \$220
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Public transport	\$140 – \$220
Groceries	\$450 – \$650
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$200 – \$400
Estimated total	\$2,600 – \$4,000

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Wellington with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Wellington special — and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Wellington is the city people fall for fastest. It's small enough to feel like home within weeks, but rich enough — culture, food, film, politics — that you never run out of things to do.

If you value walkability and a creative, connected city life over space, Wellington is hard to beat. Just pack a good jacket for the wind.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Wellington — from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Wellington offers harbourside apartments, characterful hillside villas and suburban family homes, with the Hutt Valley and Kāpiti adding more space within commuting distance.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Wellington — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Te Aro & the CBD

Apartments in the heart of the city, walkable to work, dining and the waterfront.

Mount Victoria & Thorndon

Characterful inner suburbs of heritage villas close to town.

Newtown & Berhampore

Diverse, lively suburbs near the regional hospital.

Hutt Valley & Kāpiti

More space and family homes a train ride from the city.

Across the wider region

Te Aro & the CBD

Apartments in the heart of the city, walkable to everything.

Mount Victoria & Thorndon

Heritage villas in characterful inner suburbs.

Newtown & Berhampore

Diverse, lively suburbs near the regional hospital.

Hutt Valley & Kāpiti

More space and family homes a train ride from the city.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend – check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Wellington offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

Lambton Quay & Willis St

The 'Golden Mile' — the city's main retail strip.

Cuba Street

Bohemian boutiques, vintage and independent shops.

Queensgate (Lower Hutt)

The region's largest mall, across the harbour.

Markets

Harbourside Market and the underground markets for food and craft.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Wellington has Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World across the city and suburbs, plus Moore Wilson's for fresh and bulk. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Wellington is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

Halal and Indian grocers serve the central suburbs; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Asian groceries

Excellent Asian supermarkets and restaurants, especially around the CBD and Newtown.

World food

Wellington's celebrated food scene spans every cuisine — it has more eateries per capita than New York.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Wellington reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Wellington has churches of many denominations, mosques, Hindu and Buddhist temples, and a Jewish community.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

Culture, coast and hills

Wellington rewards explorers – ride the Cable Car, walk the town belt, browse Te Papa, or escape to the Wairarapa wine country and Kāpiti coast.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: MOUNT VICTORIA LOOKOUT / CUBA STREET

Don't-miss experiences

- Ride the Cable Car to the Botanic Garden
- Explore Te Papa on the waterfront
- Walk or bike the Mount Victoria lookout
- Day-trip to Martinborough's wineries

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Wellington and the wider region.

- 1 Te Papa**
NZ's national museum on the waterfront – free to enter.
- 2 Wellington Cable Car**
Ride up to the Botanic Garden and lookout.
- 3 Mount Victoria lookout**
The classic view over the harbour and city.
- 4 Zealandia**
A world-first urban eco-sanctuary.
- 5 Cuba Street**
The city's creative, café-lined heart.
- 6 Weta Workshop**
Go behind the scenes of NZ's film industry.
- 7 Waterfront walk**
Stroll from Te Papa to Oriental Bay.
- 8 Wellington Zoo**
The country's oldest zoo.
- 9 Mount Kaukau**
A hilltop walk with panoramic views.
- 10 Martinborough day trip**
Wairarapa wine country an hour away.

Travel from Wellington

Wellington is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Martinborough & Wairarapa (~1.5 hrs)

Wine country and charming towns.

Kāpiti Coast (~45 min)

Beaches and Kāpiti Island nature reserve.

Picton & Marlborough (ferry)

Cross Cook Strait to the South Island.

Palmerston North (~2 hrs)

The lower North Island's friendly student city.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Wellington offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Wellington for families

Beyond school and work, Wellington is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Te Papa, the waterfront and the Botanic Garden – much of the best fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

Te Papa, Capital E, the zoo and Zealandia keep kids busy.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

Compact and walkable, with frequent trains and buses for families.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs – football, netball, rugby, swimming – are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Wellington has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Wellington", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Wellington would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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